

ELLADUNHAMEDITED

Travel Radio Australia and we're in London at the World Travel Market which is one of the biggest events for the travel industry and I've run into Ella Dunham and Ella is the Head of Marketing at Exus Travel. She's also an AWTE Communications Director. She does under 30 travel and she's a travel journalist and writer.

Ella, welcome to the program. Hello, thank you for having me. Now, how did you get into the travel world? You were telling me a very interesting story.

How did it all happen? Yeah, very random. I started out a social media page when I was 13 years old. I can't believe my parents allowed me free reign at that point but it was for a band and then I was telling people how to meet them and it garnered up to probably about 960,000 followers at the time and it kind of spiraled from there.

I was meeting hoteliers and yeah, carried on in social media and that's how I ended up in marketing. It was a really amazing opportunity straight out of school and I went to work for a tour operator and it's kind of gone from there. Can you say who the band was? It was very embarrassing, One Direction.

Whoa! I'm sure they were like over the moon as well and you were a super fan, were you? I was a super fan. It got to a point where it was so big that their management emailed us. Actually, they messaged us on Twitter and said, please stop.

So we did. We wanted to keep them safe. But yeah, it went on for years and there were so many amazing opportunities.

I was interviewed by Rolling Stone magazine about it on their 10-year anniversary. But I do think it's a very strange start to the travel industry and quite unusual but definitely gave me the skills I needed for now. It's a fantastic thing that you're doing now.

Tell us about the AWTE. What does that stand for? So it's the Association of Women Travel Executives. They have been around since I think the 1920s and was founded in England by a team of ladies who just wanted to get the best out of women in the industry and create opportunities for them.

And that's been a really amazing opportunity to meet incredible women in the industry and it's a voluntary role and there's a team I think of 12 on the board and we all do it in our spare time. But they're known for their legendary Christmas lunches, which are a little bit raucous. A really amazing association and they've done so much for women in the industry.

And yeah, really proud to be a part of it. And you've been crowned the AWTE Rising Star of the Year. That's a fantastic award.

Yeah, I wasn't expecting that, to be honest. And that's actually how I ended up on the board. I won their Rising Star of the Year award in 2023 and then they invited me to be part of the board, which was a very proud moment for me.

And some of the people that have been the Rising Star of the Year have got the most incredible careers. So I'm very happy to be amongst them. Very lucky.

And tell us about your role. You're Head of Marketing at Exus Travel. That's E-X-S-U-S.

Tell us about this organisation. Yeah, so Exus Travel has been going for about 26 years now. They started out as a South America specialist and have now worldwide luxury, very high-end products.

And I mean, the luxury market's changed. So I think it's now about experiences and doing things that are off the beaten track and doing things that other people haven't. I think the places, when I think about it and the trips I've also done with Exus, the places I've loved the most are those that aren't overpopulated by tourists.

So I think there's so many far-flung destinations that we've got to explore that we don't all need to go to the same ones. And they're excellent at what they do. I love my job.

I'm so lucky. And yeah, that we have an amazing array of specialists who covered the different destinations around the world. And they've all lived in the areas that they sell or have very extensive knowledge of them.

So again, very proud to work for them. And tell us some of your favourite destinations. You get to fly all over the world, stay at the most beautiful places.

Tell us a couple of your gems. A gem of this year, actually, I was very lucky to visit Samoa. And I just think it's the most beautiful place I've ever been.

I've never experienced culture like that. And it's like stepping back in time and seeing the sense of community that I think it's actually lost in our generation. And it's beautiful to see the way that everyone interacts with each other.

And also, again, we're going to the most popular tourist spots in Samoa. And there's no one there. I was in a waterfall by myself.

And it felt like such a pinch me moment. I actually felt like I was in Avatar. Yeah, just an incredible place.

And another one for me is the Philippines. I think the people there, I've never met anyone so friendly. And there are so many unexplored destinations within the country.

And I mean, an abundance of islands to explore. I don't think you could ever get around them all. And yeah, there's so many, so many.

I've visited over 50, yeah, 54 countries now. So slowly getting there. You're just a young woman, you're in your 20s.

And it's incredible that you're living this fabulous lifestyle. And you get paid for it as well. I know, I pinch myself very regularly.

And I am so grateful for all the opportunities I've had. I think it's I do get quite bad imposter syndrome, actually, because it's all happened very quickly. And I mean, some of the places I've seen, I know that, you know, I'm so privileged that I can call this a job and you know, to write about it.

And I think the only downside is you go and you do these things, and you're usually by yourself. So I think the only downside to travel if there is one is just that, you know, it'd be nice to see it with family and friends. And yeah.

Well, I tried that a few times, it didn't work out for me, because I'm a bit of a loner, and I love to see things by myself. And, and when you're traveling around on for meals and things, it can be a lot of people think we have like the most wonderful lifestyle, we get free trips all around the world. But it is quite intense.

And it's work, it's work. And, and the schedules they have you on is incredibly intensive, isn't it? Yeah, I mean, there was one trip I did probably two years ago, we did 26 hotel visits in one day. And so when people say, Oh, you're going on holiday again, I'm saying no, it's not.

And of course, the other side to that is that we get to go and see these amazing places and experience, you know, everything within the country or the hotel that we're visiting. But ultimately, it is work. And I'm extremely grateful that the work is in the most beautiful places in the world.

And I'll never complain about that. But I mean, the early starts and late finishes can be quite intense, especially with jet lag. Oh, yeah.

And that's I always say to people when they put me on a four mil, I always say, just give me a day or two before because the worst thing you can do is get on like a 4040 hour flight and you're straight into the four mil schedule. And it's just incredible. It's very hard on you.

And you just can't catch up. You can't catch up on the sleep. I completely agree.

I mean, Samoa was one of them. It took me 52 hours to get there. And then it's a 13 hour time difference.

So you're completely, you know, your sleep schedules completely off. And I fell out of it for about

two days. And you're usually, you know, the four miles are not always very long.

And you're squeezing in a lot. So by the end of it, I think it took me two weeks to get back to normal. Yes.

And the WTM here, this is such a huge event. And a lot of people don't know about it who are not in the industry, but the world travel market is held every year here at the Excel in London. And the people you meet here and the connections you make is quite incredible.

Absolutely incredible. Can you believe I've been in the industry for nearly a decade, and this is my first WTM. But the people that I've met just yesterday, it's baffling to me.

And it's amazing that there's so many people from all over the world. And we're really lucky to be in this industry. And I think everyone here sort of feels that there's a real sense of community here to the people you meet.

And you know, I was speaking to someone yesterday, and he's a commissioner for airline. And you know, you just never know who you're going to meet or who you're talking to. Great to be around.

It's a fantastic event for the travel industry. And we all make our connections and do so much business here. And what's the future for you Ella, you're just going to continue traveling around the world and getting paid for it and having a wonderful time.

Well, that's the plan. I really hope so. But you know, I actually don't know what's next for me.

I think the last few years I've really spent, you know, building up my career. And maybe this is the time to just enjoy it rather than constantly striving for the next thing. So I'm quite into my wellness.

I did my yoga teacher training in India last year. So I think maybe that's a little focus on the side of work and just settle into life in London. I only moved four weeks ago.

So that's what's next. Well, Ella Dunham, it's been fantastic having you on Travel Radio Australia. And it's do come down to Australia.

Have you been so far? I have I visited Melbourne, probably about, gosh, 12 years ago. So I'm due a visit. I will be there.

Well, you fit right in in Melbourne, because you're you're pretty much a copy. And you could be the sister of Kylie Minogue. I'm sure you get that a lot.

You're the same. You're the same height, the same look, the same shape. And I'm saying that as a compliment, because I do know Kylie.

And yeah, she'd love to meet you, I think, too. Oh, I'd love to meet her. Set it up.

Ella Dunham, you can look her up. She's with AXS Travel. And how can people find out more about AXS Travel online? So you can go to [AXS.com](https://www.axstravel.com) or you can follow us on Instagram, AXS Travel.

We've got an amazing array of offers on there if you want to see what we're selling and what we can offer. Great. And that's AXS Travel.

That's fantastic. Ella, thank you very much for being on the program. Thank you so much for having me.